

CHECKLIST

# The 10-Minute Wind-Down Ritual Checklist: Fall Asleep Faster Without Medication

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*Stop doomscrolling. Start sleeping. 10 minutes is all it takes.*

**\$3.99**

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## What's Inside

- A step-by-step 10-minute pre-sleep checklist that transitions your brain out of high-alert mode and into genuine rest
- Screen-time cutoff strategy built right into the routine so you actually put the phone down without relying on willpower alone
- Nervous system reset techniques backed by sleep science — written in plain English with zero jargon
- Instant digital download you can save to your phone or print out and stick on your nightstand for nightly use

## The 10-Minute Wind-Down Ritual Checklist

### Stop Lying Awake. Start Shutting Down.

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#### HOW TO USE THIS:

Work from the top down. If you only have 10 minutes, skip to the final section. On hard nights, do only the ■ **Easy** items. Aim to hit at least 8 of the 15 items consistently — your brain will start treating them as sleep signals within a week.

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## COLOR KEY

■ **Easy** — Takes under 60 seconds, zero willpower required

■ **Medium** — Small action, noticeable payoff

■ **Effort** — Worth it, but skip on depleted nights

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## 60 MINUTES BEFORE BED

*Your brain is still in "do mode." These items begin the chemical shift.*

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### ■ 1. Dim every light in your space

Drop overhead lights. Switch to lamps, candlelight, or warm-toned bulbs (2700K or lower). Bright overhead light tells your brain it's noon. Dim light triggers melatonin release. This one change has outsized impact.

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■ **2. Set your room temperature to 65–68°F (18–20°C)**

Your core body temperature must drop to initiate sleep. Open a window, turn on a fan, or drop the thermostat now so it's cold by the time you get into bed. Cool room = faster sleep onset.

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■ **3. Put your phone in another room (or face-down, on Do Not Disturb)**

Not airplane mode. Not silent. Another room. If that's not possible, face-down with Do Not Disturb enabled. The goal: remove the object your nervous system associates with urgency and stimulation.

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■ **4. Make your last drink non-caffeinated**

Herbal tea, warm water with lemon, or plain water. This is the drink you'll finish before bed. Caffeine has a 5–7 hour half-life. That 3pm coffee is still 50% active at 8pm.

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■ **5. Change out of daywear**

Put on dedicated sleep clothes, even if it's just different clothes. This is a behavioral cue, not a comfort preference. The clothing change signals a role shift: you are no longer a person who does things.

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## **30 MINUTES BEFORE BED**

*Transition zone. Screens off. Wind-down begins in earnest.*

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■ **6. Do the Brain Dump**

Grab any scrap of paper. Set a timer for 3 minutes. Write everything sitting in your head — tomorrow's tasks, the thing you forgot to say, the worry you keep circling. No formatting, no full sentences. Just extract it.

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**Prompt to get you started:**

*"Right now I'm thinking about... and tomorrow I need to... and the thing I haven't dealt with is..."*

When the timer ends, fold the paper. It's handled for tonight. Your brain doesn't need to keep holding it.

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**■ 7. Stop all screens — TV included**

Blue light suppresses melatonin by up to 50%. More critically, content keeps your brain engaged. Even "relaxing" TV still requires attention processing. Swap for: a physical book, audiobook, podcast at low volume, or simply lying in the dim room.

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**■ 8. Do 2 minutes of light stretching or slow movement**

Not exercise. Gentle: a forward fold, shoulder rolls, a slow neck release. This shifts blood flow away from the brain, reduces cortisol slightly, and gives your body a physical signal to downshift. Floor-based is better than standing.

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**■ 9. Check tomorrow's first obligation**

Look at one thing: what time do you need to be somewhere or do something tomorrow? Set your alarm if needed. Close the app. This single act eliminates a major source of pre-sleep anxiety — the fear of oversleeping or forgetting something critical.

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**■ 10. Choose your wind-down sound environment**

Silence, white noise, rain sounds, or quiet instrumental music (no lyrics). Pick one and keep it consistent. Your brain learns to associate that sound with sleep onset. Consistency matters more than which option you pick.

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## **10 MINUTES BEFORE BED**

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*Final approach. Sensory inputs narrowing. Body preparing for unconsciousness.*

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### ■ 11. Wash your face or hands with warm water

The warmth followed by cooling mimics the body temperature drop that triggers sleep. It also creates a firm ritual endpoint — a physical full stop on the day.

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### ■ 12. Darken the room fully

Even small light sources (charging indicators, streetlight gaps in curtains) can interrupt melatonin. Use an eye mask if blackout curtains aren't possible. Total darkness is the goal.

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### ■ 13. Get into bed before you're fully exhausted

Counterintuitive: don't wait until you're falling asleep on the couch. Get into bed while drowsy but still conscious. This keeps the bed associated with sleep, not the couch, chair, or floor — and preserves the transition moment.

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### ■ 14. Do 4-7-8 breathing for 4 cycles

Inhale through nose: **4 counts**

Hold: **7 counts**

Exhale through mouth: **8 counts**

Repeat 4 times. This activates the parasympathetic nervous system. Your heart rate slows. Carbon dioxide builds slightly, which is naturally sedating. This is not meditation — it's a physiological lever.

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### ■ 15. State one specific thing from today

Not gratitude journaling. One specific moment, observation, or thing that happened. *"The coffee was actually good this morning."* *"That meeting ended faster than I expected."* Specificity shifts your brain from scanning for threats (tomorrow's problems) to processing completed experience. It's a cognitive gear change, not positivity performance.

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## YOUR HARD-NIGHT SHORTCUT

*Only have 5 minutes? Do just these:*

- Dim the lights (#1)
- Brain Dump for 90 seconds (#6)
- Darken the room (#12)
- 4-7-8 breathing, 4 cycles (#14)

Four items. Eight minutes. Still works.

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## QUICK REFERENCE TRACKER

*Check off what you did each night. You're looking for patterns, not perfection.*

| Item | M | T | W | T | F | S | S |

|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|

| 1. Dim lights | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ |

| 2. Cool room | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ |

| 3. Phone away | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ |

| 6. Brain dump | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ |

| 7. Screens off | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ |

| 14. Breathing | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ | ■ |

*Print this. Keep it on your nightstand. The act of checking boxes is itself a winding-down behavior.*

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### A NOTE ON CONSISTENCY:

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This ritual works because repetition builds neural association. The first night, it's a checklist. By night 14, it's a trigger. Your brain begins anticipating sleep before you've finished the list. Give it two weeks of partial effort before judging results.

You don't need perfect nights. You need enough consistent signals that your nervous system stops treating bedtime like a problem to solve.

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*Print at 100% on one page · Cardstock recommended · Keep on nightstand*

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Niche: Adults who lie awake at night unable to fall asleep and want a non-medication solution · Format: Checklist ·  
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